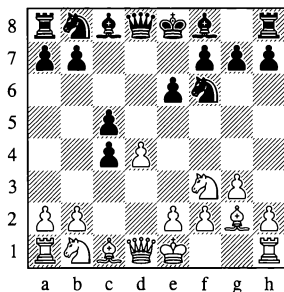


Chapter 6

Catalan 4...dxc4



Introduction to 5...c5

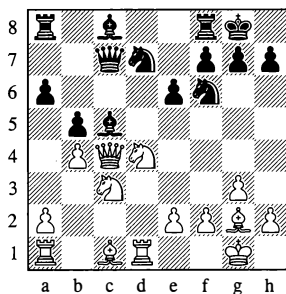
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 c5

6.0-0

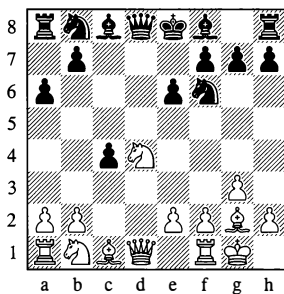
A) 6...cxd4 7.♘xd4	74
A1) 7...♙b6	75
A2) 7...♙c5	76
A3) 7...a6!?	78
B) 6...♘c6 7.♙a4 cxd4 8.♘xd4 ♙xd4 9.♙xc6† ♙d7 10.♞d1	80
B1) 10...♙xc6	82
B2) 10...♙xd1† 11.♙xd1 ♙xc6 12.♘d2	83
B21) 12...c3?!	83
B22) 12...b5	84

A2) note to 8...♙d7



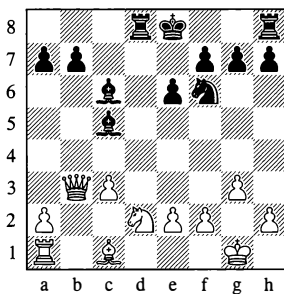
13.♘cxb5!N

A3) after 7...a6!?



8.♘c3!N

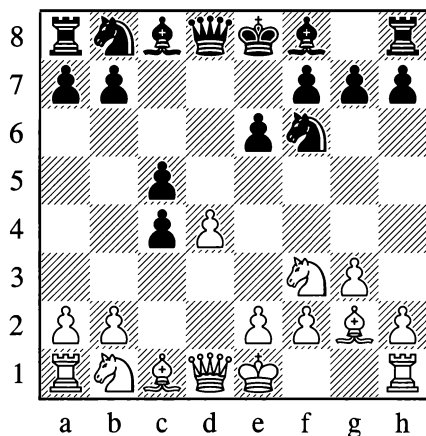
B21) after 14...♙c5



15.♘c4N

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 c5

This remains a popular variation, and it has recently been used successfully by some top grandmasters, including Vishy Anand.



6.0-0

In the Catalan it is quite common for White to build a lead in development while Black is mainly making pawn moves. Black will often then revert to catching up on development while White regains the sacrificed pawn.

Sometimes Black tries to solve his opening problems by removing the tension in the centre with A) 6...cxd4, but the more popular B) 6...♘c6 is probably a sounder approach.

6...♘bd7 transposes to variation A of Chapter 5.

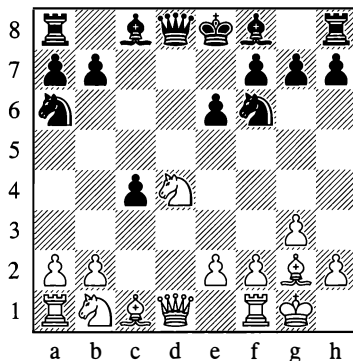
A) 6...cxd4 7.♘xd4

7.♙a4† is playable, but I see no reason to change the recommendation from *GM 1*. The three most important replies are A1) 7...♙b6, A2) 7...♙c5 and A3) 7...a6!?

7...♘a6

This move was awarded an exclamation mark in *Chess Informant* 48, but it looks strange

to me, as Black is doing nothing against White's pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal. I found no new games since *GM 1*, so the following idea remains a novelty:

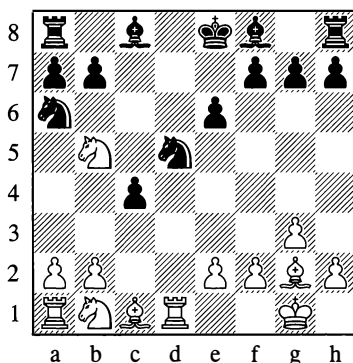


8.♘b5! N ♙xd1

8...♘c7 9.♙xd8† ♘xd8 10.♘5a3!? and White will be clearly better after regaining the pawn on c4.

8...♙d7 9.♘d6† ♙xd6 10.♙xd6 ♘b5 11.♙xd8† ♙xd8 12.♘a3 ♙c6 13.♙xc6† bxc6 14.♘xc4± White has a pleasant edge, thanks to Black's damaged pawn structure on the queenside.

9.♙xd1 ♘d5



10.♘1c3! ♙d7 11.♘xd5 ♙xb5 12.♘c3 ♙c6 13.♙xc6† bxc6 14.♙d4 ♘b4 15.♙xc4

White has an obvious advantage.

7...♘d5?!

This move has been employed at a high level, but it cannot be recommended.

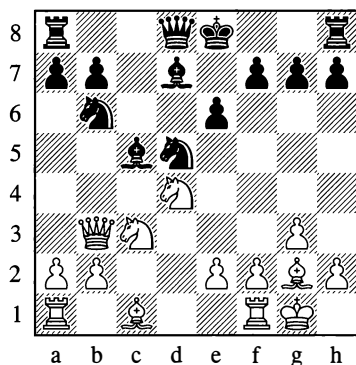
8. ♖a4† ♜d7 9. ♜xc4 ♜7b6 10. ♜b3 ♙d7
After 10...♙c5 Kramnik gives 11. ♜b5† ♜d7
12. ♜b3 with White's advantage.

11. ♜c3

11. e4!?N might be a worthy alternative.

11...♙c5

11...♜xc3 12. ♜xc3 ♜c8 13. ♜d3 leaves Black under pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal.



12. ♜xd5 ♜xd5

12...exd5 gives White a pleasant edge after
13. ♙e3 or 13. ♜e3† ♜e7 14. b3.

Now White found a nice tactical resource:

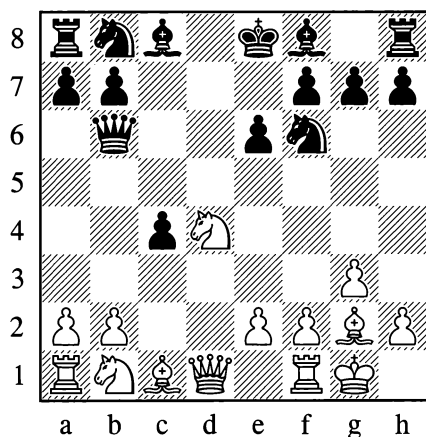
13. ♜f5! 0-0

In the event of 13...exf5 14. ♜xd5± Black loses the b7-pawn.

14. ♜xg7!±

White won a pawn in Kramnik – Naiditsch, Turin (ol) 2006, as 14...♜xg7 would be met by 15. ♙xd5 followed by 16. ♜c3† and 17. ♜xc5.

A1) 7...♜b6



This move has some tricky ideas, but White has a clear route to an advantage.

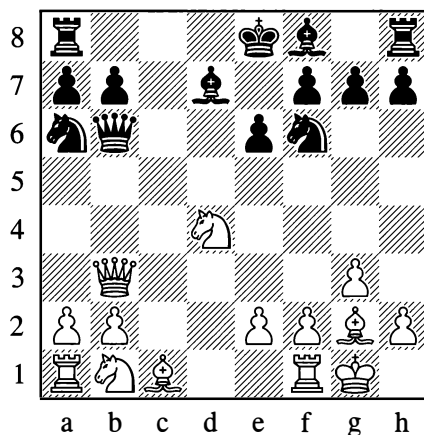
8. ♖a4† ♙d7 9. ♜xc4 ♜a6

The key move, intending to exploit the slight vulnerability of the white pieces in the centre by means of ...♜c8 and perhaps ...♜c5.

9...e5 10. ♜b3 ♙c6 is hardly an improvement. In Romanishin – Podlesnik, Ljubljana 1997, White should have played 11. ♙g5 ♙e7 12. ♜c3 ♙xg2 13. ♜xg2 ♜c6† 14. ♜xc6† ♜xc6 15. ♜fd1± when Black faces an unpleasant endgame.

10. ♜b3!

This strong move enables White to solve his problems tactically while at the same time grabbing the initiative.



10...♜b4

10...♜c5 11. ♜xb6 axb6 12. ♜c3 leaves Black with an unpleasant endgame in view of his weaknesses on the queenside.

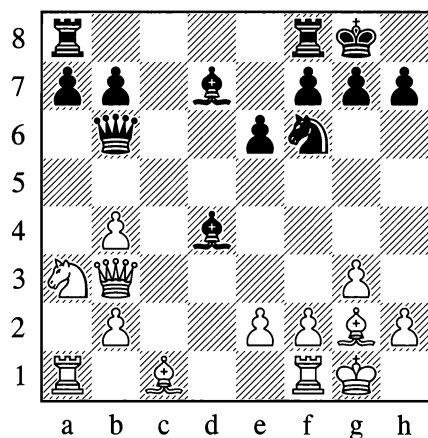
11. a3 ♙c5

Other moves also fail to bring Black much relief:

11...♜bd5 12. ♜xb6 axb6 13. e4± gives White a pleasant advantage.

11...♖xd4 12.♙e3 ♜d6 13.axb4 ♙c6 14.♙c5
♜b8 15.♙xf8 ♜xf8 16.♙xc6† bxc6 17.♞c1±
gave White a big advantage in Swinkels – Van
der Wiel, Groningen 2009.

12.axb4 ♙xd4 13.♞a3 0–0

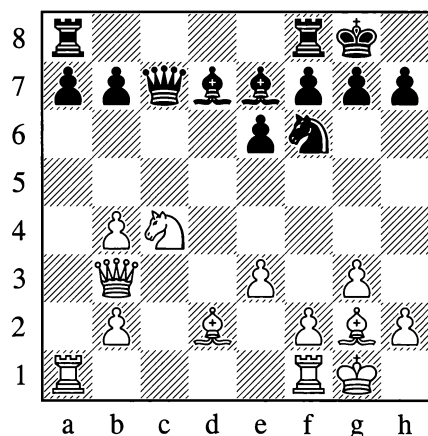


14.e3!

14.♞c4 was not so convincing in Razuvaev
– Murey, London 1983.

14...♙c5 15.♙d2 ♙e7 16.♞c4 ♜c7

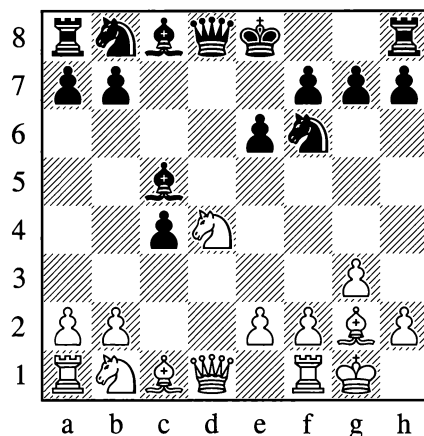
Now in Atakisi – Hofstetter, email
2005, instead of putting the knight on a5
immediately, White should have first played:



17.♞fc1N±

With strong pressure.

A2) 7...♙c5



This move looks natural, but White has a
forcing route to an advantage.

8.♜a4! ♜d7

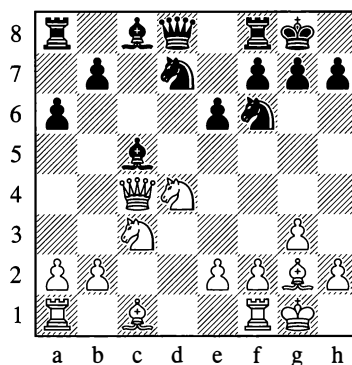
The alternative is:

8...♞bd7

This is not covered in *GM 1*, but Aronian
has used it twice against Gelfand, albeit at
fast time controls.

9.♜xc4 0–0 10.♞c3 a6

10...♙b6?! 11.♞f3 ♜c7 occurred in Schmidt
– G. Szabo, Bucharest 2010, and now the
simple 12.♜xc7N ♙xc7 13.♞d1 a6 14.b3±
leaves Black with an unpleasant defensive task.



11.♞d1!

After 11.♞b3 ♙a7 12.♞d1 h6 Black
eventually prevailed in Gelfand – Aronian,

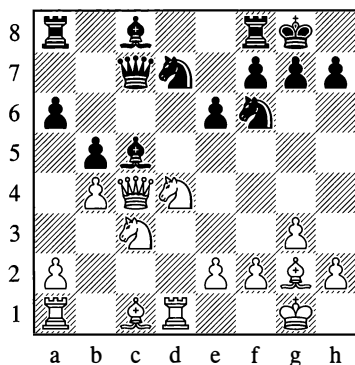
Zürich (blitz) 2014, although White is still slightly better at this point.

11...♖c7

11...b5 12.♗d3 ♜a7 13.♙e3! is an important detail, when Black faces serious tactical problems. (13.♘c6 ♗b6 14.♘xa7 ♙xf2† 15.♙h1 ♗xa7 is less clear.)

12.b4 b5

This occurred in Junge – F. Mueller, Germany 1995, and here White missed a strong idea:

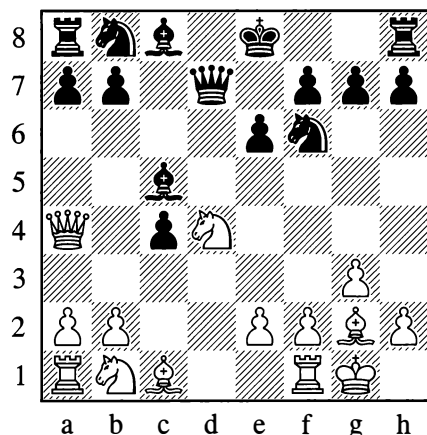


13.♘cb5! N axb5 14.♗c2

Black is in trouble, for instance:

14...♜a4 15.bxc5 ♜c4 16.♗b1 ♗xc5 17.♙e3 ♗h5 18.♙f3 ♘g4 19.♙xg4 ♗xg4 20.f3 ♗h3 21.♘xb5±

White emerges with an extra pawn.



9.♙b5!

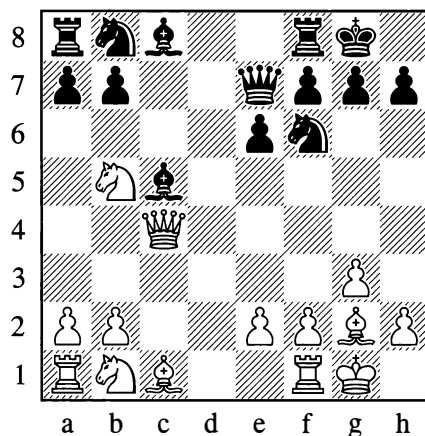
The key move.

9...0-0

9...a6? 10.♘c7† was embarrassing for Black in Kiss – Gutdeutsch, Koszeg 1996.

10.♗xc4 ♗e7

Clearly worse is 10...♙b6?! 11.♘1c3 a6 12.♘a3 ♘c6. Now in Sandipan – Tari, Gibraltar 2014, the simple 13.♙g5N would have led to clear advantage for White, for instance: 13...♘a5 14.♗h4 ♗d4 15.e4 h6 16.♙e3 ♗d8 17.♗fd1 ♘d7 18.♗xd8 ♙xd8 19.f4±



11.b4!

The natural 11.♘1c3?! gives Black an opportunity to solve his problems by means of 11...a6 12.♘d4 b5 13.♗d3 ♙b7 with equal play.

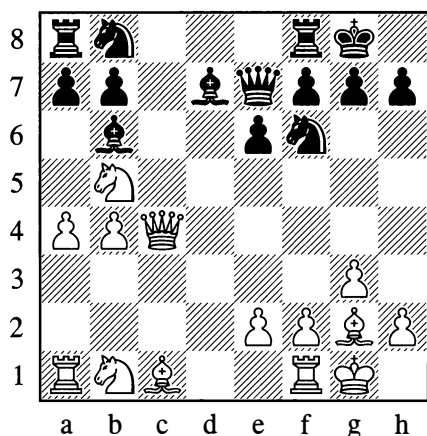
In *GM 1* I recommended 11.♘5c3 in order to prevent the above plan. However, to my great surprise I discovered 11...♘bd7!N 12.♗h4 ♜b8, when I don't see how White can prevent ...b6 and ...♙b7.

11...♙b6 12.a4

White is playing with great energy and aggression.

12...♙d7

In the event of 12...a6 13.♘5c3 ♘c6 14.♙a3 ♘e5 15.♗b3† White retains a lot of pressure.



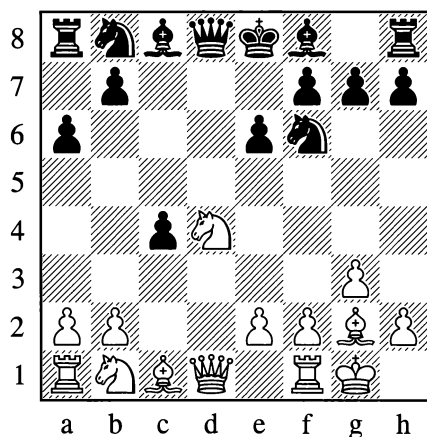
13.a5 a6

13...♙xf2? was a surprising move for an elite player, and after 14.♗xf2 ♜c8 15.♞d3 White was a healthy piece up in Gelfand – Aronian, Zürich (rapid) 2014.

14.♘5c3 ♙a7 15.♙xb7 ♙b5 16.♘xb5 ♞xb7 17.♘xa7 ♞xa7 18.♙e3 ♞a8 19.♞c1±

White had a solid extra pawn in Postny – I. Sokolov, Sibenik 2012.

A3) 7...a6!?



This move remains relatively unexplored, but it is one of the more interesting options available to Black.

8.♘c3!N

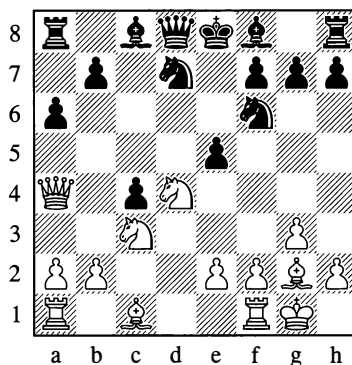
This novelty from *GM 1* remains untested, although it does briefly transpose to a game from 2009.

8.♞a4† ♞d7! 9.♞xc4 b5 10.♞b3 ♙b7 enables Black to neutralize the pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal and obtain a normal game. 11.♞d1N (11.♙xb7 ♞xb7 12.a4 b4 13.♘d2 occurred in Scheeren – Van der Wiel, Hilversum 1984, and now the simple 13...♘bd7N 14.♘c4 ♘c5 would have been equal.) 11...♙xg2 12.♗xg2 ♙c5 13.♞f3 ♞a7 Black has good chances for equality.

8...e5!N

This seems like the only critical test. Other moves are clearly worse:

The aforementioned game continued 8...♘bd7 9.♞a4 e5, and here White should have played:



10.♘f3!N (10.♘f5 ♞b8 11.♞d1 b5 12.♞c2 occurred in Czaja – Wyczawska, Rewal 2009, and now 12...♞c7!N would have been unclear.) 10...♞c7 11.♙g5 White easily seizes the initiative, for instance: 11...♞b8 12.♙xf6 gxf6 13.♘d5 ♞c6 14.♞a5!☞

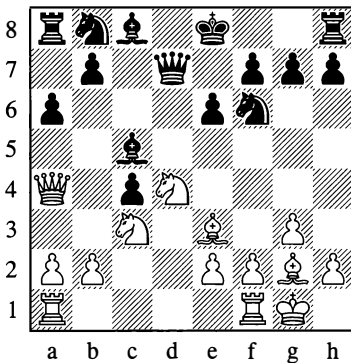
8...♙e7N 9.♞a4† ♞d7 (Also after 9...♘bd7 10.♞xc4 ♘b6 11.♞d3 Black fails to solve his opening problems.) 10.♘db5! Threatening a check on c7. (Once again White should avoid

10.♖xc4 b5 followed by ...♗b7.) 10...0-0
 11.♞d1 ♘d5 12.♙f4 White maintains a clear
 advantage, for example: 12...♘xc3 13.♘xc3
 ♗xa4 14.♘xa4 ♘d7 15.♞ac1±

8...♙c5N 9.♗a4† ♖d7 10.♙e3!

White regains the pawn under favourable
 circumstances.

10.♘db5 is less convincing here due to
 10...0-0 11.♖xc4 ♗e7 12.♘d4 b5! followed
 by ...♗b7.



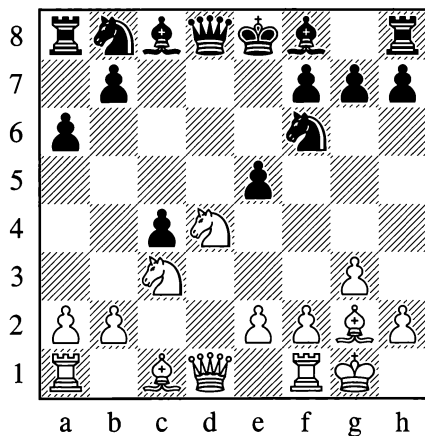
10...♗xa4 11.♘xa4 ♙a7 12.♞fc1 0-0

12...e5 13.♞xc4 0-0 14.♘c2± leaves White
 with strong pressure along the h1-a8
 diagonal.

13.♞xc4 ♘d5 14.♙xd5

14.♘f5!? also looks interesting.

14...exd5 15.♞c7±



9.♘c2!

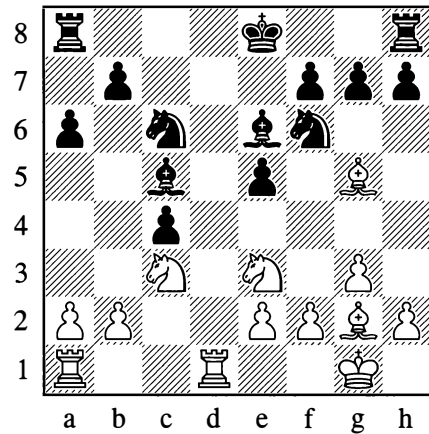
9.♘f3 ♖xd1 10.♞xd1 ♘c6 11.♙e3 ♙f5 is
 less convincing.

9...♖xd1 10.♞xd1 ♘c6 11.♙g5 ♙e6 12.♘e3

White's chances are slightly preferable in this
 endgame. Here are a few illustrative lines:

12...♙c5

12...♙e7 13.♙xf6 gxf6 14.♘cd5±



13.♙xf6

13.♞ac1 is a serious alternative. 13...♙xe3
 14.♙xe3 ♞d8 (After 14...0-0 15.♘a4! White
 will regain the pawn in a favourable situation.)
 This way Black holds on to his extra pawn,
 but after 15.♙c5 ♞xd1† 16.♞xd1 ♘d7 17.♙a3
 ♘d8 18.♘e4♞ White has nice compensation.

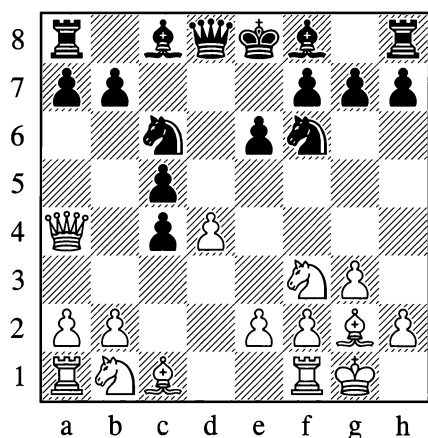
13...gxf6 14.♘ed5 0-0-0

14...♙xd5?! would be premature in view
 of 15.♞xd5 ♙d4 16.e3 ♙xc3 17.bxc3 ♘e7
 18.♞b1 ♞ab8 19.♞c5 and Black is under
 unpleasant pressure.

15.♘xf6±

White's position is more flexible and the
 knight on f6 rather restricts Black's forces.

B) 6...♟c6 7.♞a4

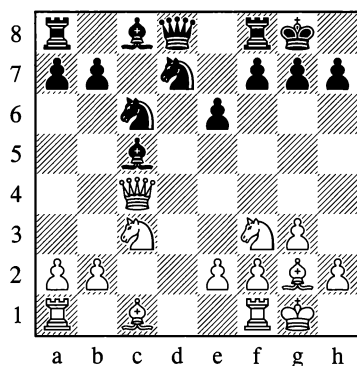


From this position the main move is 7...♞d7, which is examined in the next chapter. Before then, we will focus on the following principled alternative:

7...cxd4

Some other moves have been tried, but I do not regard any of them as serious options for Black, so I have just given a few examples of model play by White with brief accompanying notes.

7...♞d7 8.dxc5 ♞xc5 9.♞xc4 0-0 10.♞c3
Such positions without c- and d-pawns, in which the black bishop remains stuck on c8, almost always favour White in the Catalan. One example continued:



10...a6 11.♞d1 ♞b6 12.♞e4 ♞e7 13.b3 ♞f6 14.♞b2 ♞xe4 15.♞xe4± White had strong pressure in Bischoff – Sonntag, Germany 1987.

7...♞b6 8.♞a3!

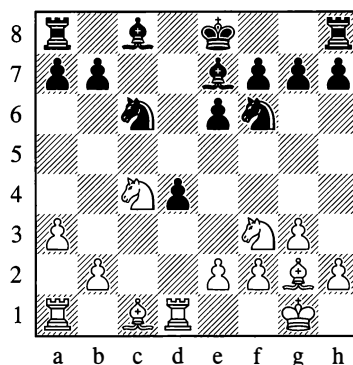
White immediately uses the placement of the black queen to win a tempo.

8...cxd4 9.♞xc4 ♞b4

Otherwise the previous queen move would be absolutely senseless.

10.♞xb4 ♞xb4 11.a3 ♞e7 12.♞d1

White will regain the pawn with a typical Catalan edge in the ensuing endgame.



12...♞d5

Trying somehow to neutralize White's pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal.

13.♞xd4 ♞xd4 14.♞xd4 ♞d7 15.e4

15.♞e3 ♞f6 16.♞d3 was equally strong.

15...♞c5

The lesser evil was 15...♞b6 16.♞d6† ♞xd6 17.♞xd6 ♞c8 18.b3, although White's bishop pair gives him a pleasant edge.

16.♞d2 ♞b6 17.♞a5±

Nesis – Galdanov, USSR 1975.

A final alternative is:

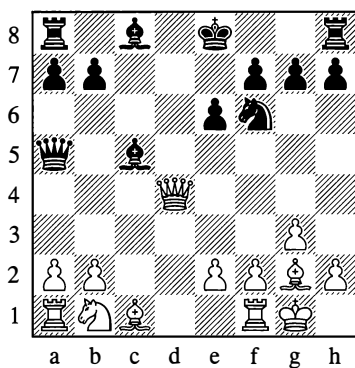
7...♞a5 8.♞xc4 cxd4

8...b5 9.♞c2 ♞b4 has occurred in six games, but no one found the strongest reply: 10.♞d2!N (After 10.♞d1 ♞b7 Black is all right). The main point can be seen in

the following line: 10...♙b7 11.dxc5 ♙xc5 12.♖g5! ♙f8 13.♙d2 h6 14.♖h4± Black is behind in development and his knight is in an awkward pin.

9.♟xd4 ♟xd4 10.♖xd4 ♙c5

This seems like the best attempt to justify Black's 7th move.



11.♖c3! ♙b4

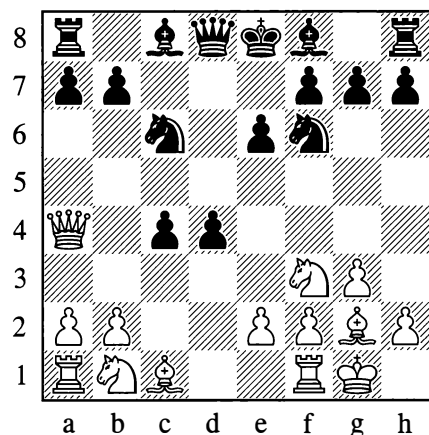
11...♖xc3 12.♟xc3 gives White a typical endgame initiative.

12.♖b3 0–0 13.a3 ♙e7

Now in Machelett – Poschke, Berlin 1993, White could have secured an advantage with:

14.♟c3N

Black is under heavy pressure on the queenside.



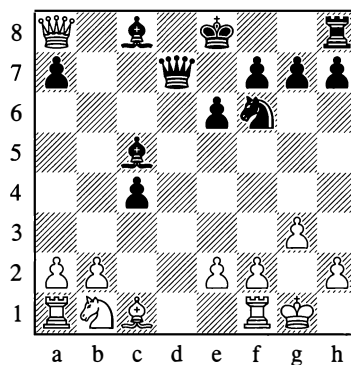
8.♟xd4 ♖xd4

Black should obviously avoid 8...♙d7?! 9.♟xc6 ♖b6 (9...bxc6 10.♟d1 ♟d5 11.♖xc4 ♙e7 occurred in the recent game Schlosser – Sochacki, Pardubice 2013, and here 12.e4N ♟b6 13.♖c2 0–0 14.♙f4± would have given White an indisputable positional advantage) 10.♟d2 ♙xc6 11.♙xc6† ♖xc6 12.♖xc6† bxc6 13.♟xc4± with a pleasant endgame advantage for White, Rise – T. Olafsson, corr. 1995.

9.♙xc6† ♙d7

9...bxc6?! 10.♖xc6† ♖d7 11.♖xa8 ♙c5

I noticed this exchange sacrifice mentioned in one of the Dvoretzky books, where he evaluated it as an interesting idea. Indeed it looks so, but once you arm yourself with an engine things suddenly become shaky for Black!

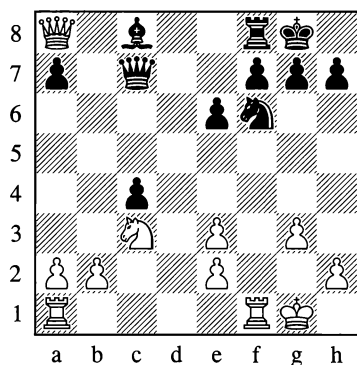


12.♙e3! ♙xe3 13.fxe3 0–0 14.♟c3 ♖c7

14...♙a6 15.♖f3 ♙b7 16.e4 ♖c7 was no better in Eslon – Gonzales, Coria del Rio 1995, in view of 17.♟ad1N ♖b6† 18.♖f2, with an exact transposition to the main line below, with one less move played.

14...♙b7 15.♖xa7 ♖c6 16.♟f3 e5 17.♖a5 ♖e6 18.♟d1! ♙xf3 19.exf3± saw White return the exchange to secure his kingside while remaining a healthy pawn up in Ladanyi – D. Berczes, Budapest 2001.

The text move occurred in Diaz Hollemaert – Aguiar, Blumenau 2013. Here White should have played:



15.♖ad1N

With the following point:

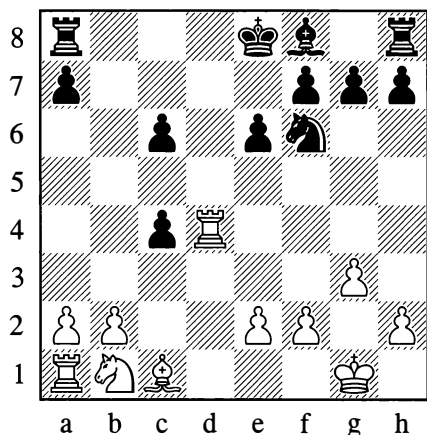
15...♜b6 16.♜f3 ♔b7 17.♜f4 ♜c6 18.e4
♜b6† 19.♜f2 ♜xb2 20.♜d4

With a clear advantage.

10.♞d1

This is the only way for White to fight for the advantage. We will analyse **B1)** 10...♙xc6 and **B2)** 10...♜xd1†.

B1) 10...♙xc6 11.♜xc6† bxc6 12.♞xd4



This position has occurred in a lot of games, but it is obvious that Black is fighting for the draw, while White can press for a long time without taking any risks. Many moves have been tested, but the general ideas are the same, so I will just mention a few instructive lines.

12...c5

12...♙e7 13.♞xc4 ♔d7 14.♞d2 ♞d5 occurred in Kessler – Farago, Triesen 2013, and now 15.e4N ♞b6 16.♞c2 c5 17.♞f3 ♞hc8 18.♙e3± would have been pretty unpleasant for Black.

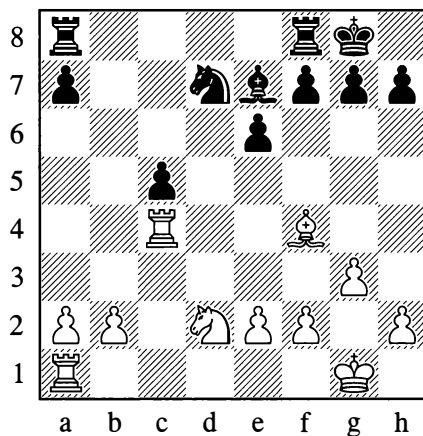
12...♞d5 13.♞xc4 ♔d7 14.e4 ♞b6 15.♞c2 f5 was played in the recent game, Krush – Zatonkih, Saint Louis 2014. Here the simple 16.♙e3N fxe4 17.♞c3 would have brought White a clear positional advantage.

13.♞xc4 ♙e7

This is one of the more popular continuations, and has been played by Mamedyarov, but I like White's play in the following encounter.

14.♙f4 0-0 15.♞d2 ♞d7

15...♞d5 16.♞e4 also leads to White's pleasant advantage.



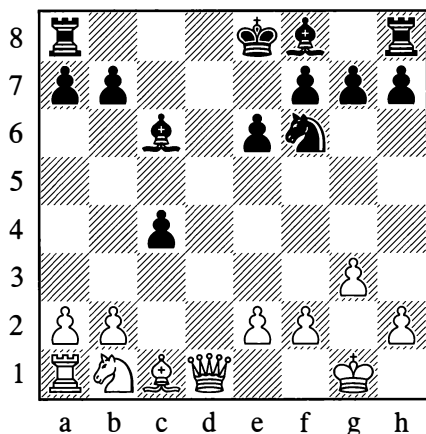
16.♞b3 a5 17.♞d1 ♞b6

This position occurred in Vladimirov – Ghaem Maghami, Kelamabakkam 2000, and here the most accurate continuation would have been:

18.♞cc1N ♞fc8 19.♞d2±

Intending to put the knight on c4. Black is still a long way from a draw.

B2) 10...♖xd1† 11.♗xd1 ♕xc6

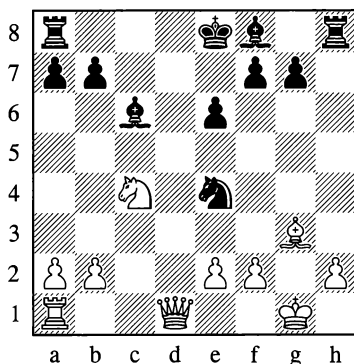


For the moment Black has full material equality for the queen, but the c4-pawn is rather weak.

12.♘d2

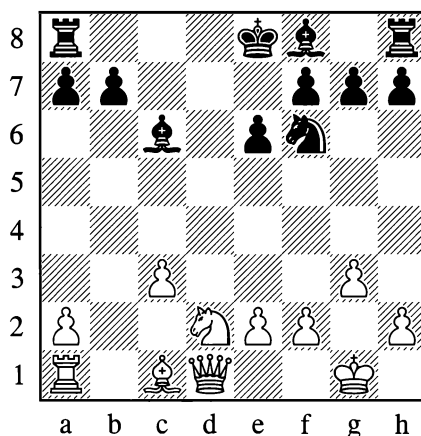
Now we will consider the somewhat dubious **B21) 12...c3?! and the more reliable B22) 12...b5.**

12...h5?! 13.♘xc4 h4 14.♕f4! is clearly in White's favour: 14...hxg3 (14...♗d8 15.♗b3 hxg3 16.♕xg3 ♘e4 17.♘e5 ♘xg3 occurred in Vanheste – Blauert, Groningen 1989, and now after 18.fxg3N ♕c5† 19.e3± White is ready to eliminate the light-squared bishop, after which the c6-pawn will become a target.) 15.♕xg3 ♘e4



16.♘e5! ♘xg3 17.♘xc6! ♘xe2† 18.♗xe2 bxc6 19.♗a6 ♕d6 20.♗xc6† ♖e7 21.♗b7† ♖f6 22.♗f3† ♖e7 23.♗b7† ♖f6 24.♗f3† ♖e7 25.h3 In Fahnenschmidt – Herbrechtsmeier, Germany 1986, White reached what I believe to be a technically winning position, in view of his potential to create a passed pawn on the queenside.

B21) 12...c3?! 13.bxc3



It looks tempting to damage White's structure, but now White does not have to spend time going after the c-pawn, and can instead activate his pieces and force favourable exchanges.

13...♗d8

13...0-0-0?! 14.♗b3 ♕c5 15.♘f3 ♘e4?! was too ambitious in Hjartarson – Hardarson, Neskaupsstadur 1984. At this point, the surprising 16.♘e5!N ♕xf2† 17.♖f1 would already have been winning for White.

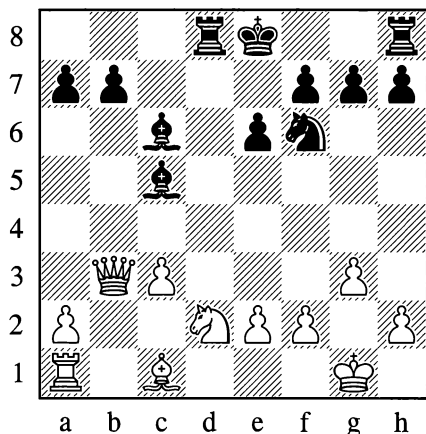
13...♕e7?! 14.♗b3 ♗d8 (14...0-0 15.♕a3 is also excellent for White) 15.♘f3 0-0 16.♘e5 was clearly better for White in V. Mikhalevski – Onischuk, Gibraltar 2011.

13...♕c5 14.♘b3 ♗d8 15.♗e1 ♕e7 was a bit more solid for Black in Nikolaidis – Bojkov, Istanbul 2001, but it gives White an

opportunity to exchange the dark-squared bishops: 16.♖d4! ♔d5 17.a4 0-0 18.♙a3 ♙xa3 19.♞xa3± White has a better version of the main variation B22 which will be analysed shortly.

14.♞b3 ♙c5

Now in Wood – Micklethwaite, corr. 1993, White missed a simple yet strong idea:



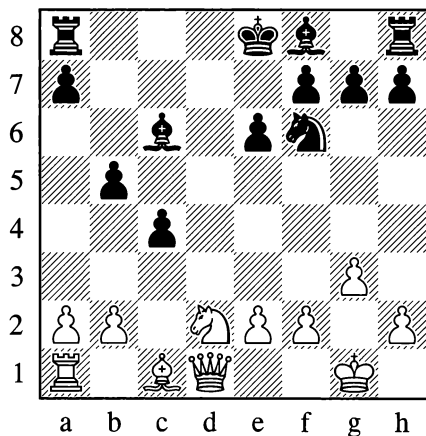
15.♖c4N ♖e4

15...♖g4? 16.♙a3! ♙xf2† 17.♙f1 is winning for White.

16.♙e3 ♙xe3 17.♖xc3±

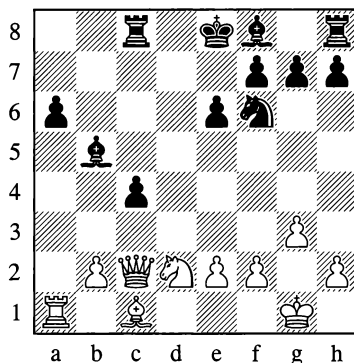
The trade of dark-squared bishops obviously favours White.

B22) 12...b5



13.a4 ♙e7

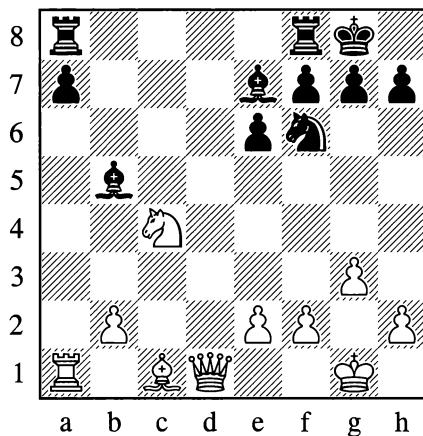
It is impossible for Black to keep all of his queenside pawns, and he should not waste his time trying: 13...a6? 14.axb5 ♙xb5 (Even worse is 14...axb5? 15.♞xa8† ♙xa8 16.♖xc4!+— when the b-pawn will soon be lost as well.) 15.♞c2 ♙c8



16.♞xa6! Without this finesse Black would be okay. 16...♙xa6 17.♞a4† ♖d7 18.♞xa6 ♙d8 19.♖xc4 ♙e7 20.♖a5! ♖b8 21.♞b5† ♙f8 22.♙f4+— Kochyev – Kilpi, Jyvaskyla 1996.

14.axb5 ♙xb5 15.♖xc4 0-0

This position was tested several times in the mid-1980s but, even though White was having a hard time proving a clear advantage, it then disappeared for a couple of decades before making a comeback in more recent years. When the Dutch grandmaster Erwin L'Ami played it against me in the Bundesliga in 2008, I was forced to improvise.



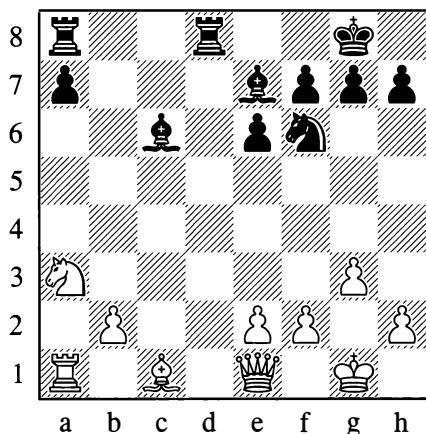
16.♟a3!?

This is what I came up with at the board, and home analysis has given me no reason to deviate from it.

A well-known theoretical line is 16.b3 ♜fd8 17.♞c2 ♜dc8! 18.♙a3 ♙xa3 19.♞xa3 ♞c7 20.♞a5 ♙xc4 21.bxc4 h6 and I do not see any real winning chances for White, as Black will soon trade his a-pawn for White's c-pawn.

16...♞fd8 17.♞e1 ♙c6

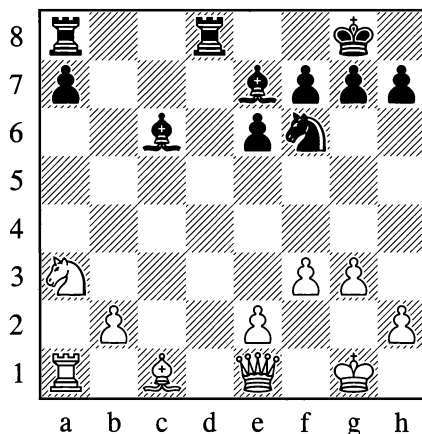
17...♙e8 occurred in Figura – Stern, Berlin 2009, but 18.♟c4N seems promising, for instance 18...♟d5 19.♙d2 ♙b5 20.♟e5± and White continues to improve his position.

**18.f3!**

My game continued: 18.♙d2 ♞ab8 19.♙f4 ♞xb2 20.♞c1 ♞b3! (Stronger than 20...♙xa3 21.♞xc6 ♙f8 22.♞xa7 ♞xe2 23.♙g5 when White has some initiative.) 21.♞xc6 ♞xa3 22.♞b1 ♟d5 23.♙e5 ♞a2 After losing the last of the queenside pawns, White's winning chances were diminished in Avrukh – L'Ami, Germany 2008.

The text move is my suggested improvement from *GM 1*, which has since been employed in one game, although the move order was slightly different. White's plan is to improve

his position on the kingside with moves like ♟g2 and e2-e4, while avoiding unnecessary exchanges – especially of the last remaining queenside pawns. A useful point to keep in mind is that situations with opposite-coloured bishops will tend to favour White, as he will be able to attack the dark squares on the kingside. Black's position is pretty solid, but he is unable to do much other than sit and defend.

**18...♟d5**

I considered this as a sideline in *GM 1*, but will look at it more closely here, as it was played in the one practical encounter to have taken place since then.

18...♙c5†N 19.♟g2 ♟d5 20.♙d2 threatens ♞c1, and after 20...♙d4 21.e4 ♟b6 22.♙c3 White keeps a nice edge.

18...♞ab8N

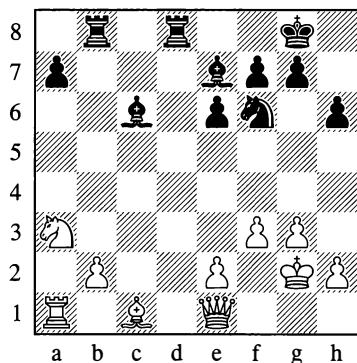
I mainly focused on this move in *GM 1*.

19.♟g2 h6

19...♟d5 transposes to the main line.

19...♞b7 20.♟c4 ♙d5 21.♟e5 ♞c8 22.e4 ♞c2† 23.♟h3 The king is surprisingly safe here! 23...♙b3 24.♙e3 ♞xb2 25.♙xa7!± 19...♞b3 20.♟c4 ♙b5 21.♟a5 ♙b4 22.♞f1 ♙xa5 23.♞xa5 a6 24.♙a3!± As mentioned earlier, the presence of opposite-coloured bishops gives White attacking chances.

Here I found an improvement over my analysis in *GM 1*.

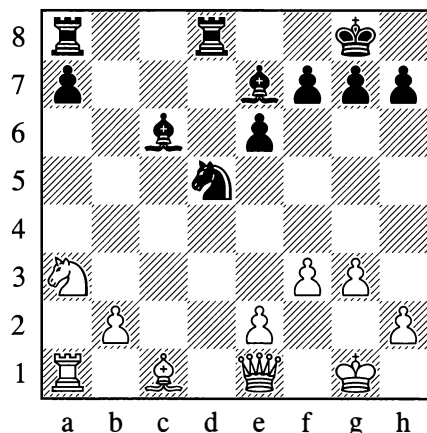


20.♖c2!

Previously I gave: 20.♖c4 ♗d5 21.♖e5 (21.♖e3 ♗b4 22.♜f1 ♗c5 23.♖xd5 ♖xd5 24.♖h3 ♖e3=) 21...♗d6 22.♖d3 e5!? Trying to create counterplay. 23.e4 (23.♞xa7?! e4 24.fxe4 ♗xe4† 25.♖f1 ♖g4 leaves White's king too exposed.) 23...♗c4 24.♖f2 Now instead of 24...a6, Black can play 24...♗b4! 25.♜e3 a5 when it is hard for White to improve his position.

20...♞b7 21.e4±

White will continue to improve his pieces, while retaining the all-important queenside pawn.



19.♖g2 ♞ab8 20.♖c4

This is a suitable moment to jump with the knight.

20...♗b5 21.b3 a6 22.♗a3 ♗xc4

My previous analysis concluded 22...♗f6 23.♞c1±.

23.♗xe7 ♖xe7N

23...♞c8? was an inexplicable mistake, and after 24.bxc4 ♖xe7 25.♞xa6 White was obviously winning in Giemsa – Jahnz, Berlin 2009.

24.bxc4 ♞dc8 25.♜c3 ♞c6 26.♞d1 ♖g6 27.♞d4±

This position can be compared with the drawish 16.b3 line as given in the notes above. The big differences here are that Black's knight is misplaced and White has real chances to create threats on the kingside.

Conclusion

5...c5 6.0–0 remains an important branch of the Catalan. After 6...cxd4 7.♖xd4 White has good chances for an advantage based on his thematic pressure on the long diagonal, although it helps to be aware of a few important nuances in certain lines.

The main line is 6...♖c6 7.♜a4, when this chapter dealt with the forcing option of 7...cxd4 8.♖xd4 ♜xd4 9.♗xc6† ♗d7 10.♞d1, when Black must decide what type of position to defend. 10...♗xc6 leads to a slight, risk-free endgame advantage for White, while 10...♜xd1† 11.♜xd1 ♗xc6 12.♖d2 leads to an interesting situation with queen against pieces. With the ideas presented here, White has good chances to put his opponent under long-term pressure.